‘outsiders’ could enjoy to the full the short time they got to spend in these splendid, sylvan surroundings.

We were conscious that the place was on loan to us for the period of our stay and wanted to share it to the fullest. And so it was that, on more than one occasion, we made it available for the celebration of Diwali by the Carmichael Road Walkers’ Association—the lights, fireworks and delicious Diwali food contributing to evenings filled with joy, cheer and bonhomie. On another occasion, towards the end of my tenure, we hosted the Asia Society for an evening of ‘exploring the heritage’ of the bungalow. An expert they brought along conducted a tour of the bungalow for us, explaining the history of the architectural design and the ancestry of every piece of furniture and furnishing. I knew I was an ignoramus on heritage issues; even so, the realization that I was so much of a boor that I had remained indifferent to the rich heritage of the surroundings I had inhabited for nearly five years left me shamed.

In terms of actual time spent in and on the bungalow, I must confess to having been an indifferent, if not a poor, householder. But when I open my ‘inward eye’, I recall many a moment spent enjoying the ‘atmosphere’ of it, revelling in the open spaces, the fresh air wafting in through the many large windows, the cacophony of birds that converged on the lawn for a last diatribe before they settled down to another night in the snug foliage. I close my eyes and see the heavy bunches of jackfruit which every season bent the branches of the tree that peeped in at our bedroom window.

In particular, I remember 2010, a year of battering rains in Mumbai when, on occasional Sunday mornings, I would sneak downstairs and stretch out on the leather couch tucked into the semicircular alcove opposite the main staircase, ostensibly to do some serious reading. But the soothing strains of the interminable rain, the luxury of having someone else attend to the opening and closing of windows and doors as the deluge revived or abated, sent me into an almost comatose state far removed from the ‘fever and fret’ of real life. I must, however, confess that every such occasion was invariably vitiated by twinges of guilt at the thought of millions of Mumbai